

Ubuntu Prototype

Ubuntu Prototypes is a new feature which will have face detection like on many Windows laptops

Casio EX-Z2300

Casio's new Exilim EX-Z2300 camera comes with a 14.1 MP sensor, a 3-inch LCD, 5x optical zoom and can also record 720p videos

The correct terminology should be LED-backlit TVs, or LED LCD TVs. True LED TVs are yet to arrive. What's important to note is that these LED-backlit TVs offer slightly better contrast ratios. It's not an essential feature that every TV ought to have. The other benefit of LED TVs is that they can be slim. Buying a slim TV is great if you have plans of wall mounting the TV.

The only problem here is the price of the product. Like with any new technology, there is a premium you pay. Today, you can buy an LED-backlit TV for 30 to 40 per cent more than a traditional LCD. You can buy a decent 40-inch LED-backlit TV for around ₹60,000. As time progresses, LED TVs are bound to get a little cheaper like with any other technology.

For the moment though, most of us do not absolutely need a thin display and there isn't much of a performance improvement over the early line of LED TVs.

S-IPS panels

S-IPS panels are considered to be the best when it comes to colour rendition and viewing angles. However, most popular brands use IPS or S-IPS panels. Some brands don't advertise the IPS panel bit enough, so only if you don't see the term used, enquire about the nature of the panel. You're more likely to find that it's an IPS panel anyway. And don't think of it as a "standard" either! You should check image quality regardless, because you get both bad SIPS and good SPIS panels.

Media playback

Most TVs these days have an inbuilt media player. You can connect a portable hard drive or flash drive, and play your favorite movies and music directly from the TV. In almost all cases, however, the hardware on the TV isn't designed to play high-definition content, so you're left with a player that only plays limited formats and resolutions. The performance in the menus is also usually slow and painful. Eventually, you're going to want to buy an HTPC or a media player, so don't give this feature too much importance.

OPTICAL LIGHT EMITTING DIODE TECH

OLED is an upcoming technology and it's impressive because you can now have a really thin display with excellent performance. Unfortunately, it's still far from replacing LCDs. So if you're waiting for the next big thing, it's still going to take a couple of years before you can go out and buy one for say, ₹50,000 or so. The only decent OLED demonstrations have come from LG and Sony in the last couple of months. LG's prototype shown at IFA 2010 is expected to be around £6000 (approximately ₹430,000)

HYPE: 3DTVs

3D-anything is a catchphrase these days. With the arrival of 3D movies in cinemas, it's only normal to expect 3D movies at home. Some brands have been seen selling these TVs, but the fact remains that there are very few, or almost no 3D movies in the market. In India, it's far worse. Here, we're still to see very affordable Blu-ray HD movies. 3D TVs might be interesting for the future, but for now,



Sony's NX900 LED-backlit TVs support 3D content playback

we'd like to see more HD content to begin with. Brands are also working frantically on developing 3DTVs that will not require you to use those stupid glasses. Unless you have money to burn, three or four years hence, you want to be able to upgrade from a regular

LCD/Plasma to 3D, and not stuck with a 3DTV that your friends make fun of.

The Hz wars

You've probably also seen 120Hz and 200Hz refresh rate TVs being advertised. Apparently, these let you enjoy smooth video playback. Different manufacturers use different terms for this. Since the TV broadcasts and video content you will usually watch are 24fps or 30fps (60fps in rare cases), all this Hz business is of little consequence. There is re-sampling required in most cases to play 24 and 30 fps video on a 120Hz and 200Hz TV. If anything, you might actually notice ghosting and other artifacts as all this sampling is done by hardware and software. Actually, when we test TVs, these are some of the features we choose to turn off.

Visual enhancements

Many manufacturers boast of their image processors which are capable of making picture crisper, and noise-free. Contrast and colour enhancements are common examples. What you should look for is a very natural image that hasn't been tampered with. Most TVs with these settings turned on make colours look gaudier and the image quality harsh. Sharpening is also only useful if you're sitting the required distance away from the TV, if you're too close, this will make the edges of objects look jagged. Again, we turn all such features off when testing, and you should do the same when looking at the TV on display in the showroom.

WHAT'S FOR SALE?

Everyone complains about how we have so little choice and how they'd like to get what was available in the US. So what can you really buy in

